Classroom pack: license plate readers in Sun Prairie

Everything here uses facts from sunprairiealpr.netlify.app and the sources linked there. The goal is not to tell students what to think about plate readers. It is to help them tell a statement from a contract term, a claim from evidence, and an ended contract from a ban. Facts are as of Nov. 5, 2026, so check the site before class.

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45-minute lesson plan

Fits a civics, government, media literacy or advisory unit. Needs: one device per pair, or printed case files from alpr-case-files.pdf.

0 to 5 minutes: hook

Open the “Follow one made-up car” tool on the Learn tab. Ask: how many stored reads would one family car leave in a month? Let students move the sliders and guess before you reveal the number.

5 to 15 minutes: one case, in pairs

Assign each pair a different case file. They read it, answer the “Talk about it” question in two sentences, and write one thing the story does not say.

15 to 25 minutes: you are the council

Students run the five-decision council game on the Learn tab. Ask three students to share one choice and the tradeoff they weighed.

25 to 35 minutes: whose claim is it?

Play the claims game as a class. After each statement ask: how would we find out if that is true?

35 to 45 minutes: exit ticket

Students complete the exit ticket below and hand it in.

Exit ticket

Name (optional): _____

1. In your own words, what is the difference between a statement and a contract term?

_____

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_____

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_____

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2. Pick one case file. What did that city or court decide, and what is one thing the story does not tell us?

_____

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_____

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_____

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3. Write one question you would ask your alder before a vote.

_____

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_____

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Worksheet: claim vs. evidence

A claim can be sincere and still need evidence. For each claim below, write what you would need to see to test it.

Claim A. Sun Prairie's Assistant Chief said cameras along the east corridor would have helped investigators in an October 2024 homicide (WMTV 15, Nov. 2025).

Claim B. Police in York, Maine said the cameras helped with criminal investigations and missing persons cases (Fox 23 Maine, Nov. 2026).

Claim C. The Chief said Axon would keep plate data for 14 days during a three-month trial.

Hints: How many cases, over what time? How many were solved, and how many would have been solved anyway? Is the number published or only described? Is the promise written in a contract?

Reflection: which of the three claims is easiest to check, and why?

Worksheet: contract scavenger hunt

These clauses are fictional. They were written for practice and are not from any real contract. Read them, then answer the questions.

4.2 Retention. Vendor shall store Captured Data for 30 days unless extended by Agency.
7.1 Sharing. Agency may share Captured Data with other agencies as Agency determines appropriate.
9.3 Term. This Agreement runs for 10 years and renews automatically for successive 5-year terms unless either party gives 180 days' written notice.
11.4 Termination for convenience. Agency may terminate on 90 days' notice and shall pay all fees due for the then-current term.
12.1 Data. Agency owns Captured Data. Vendor may use anonymized data to improve its services.
14.2 Audits. Vendor shall provide audit logs to Agency upon request.

1. How long is the data kept? Who can change that?
2. Who decides which other agencies get the data? Is there a requirement that the agreement be public?
3. If the city wanted to leave after year 2, what would it owe?
4. What could happen if nobody sends a notice in time?
5. What can the vendor do with the data, even though the city owns it?
6. Who has to ask for the audit logs? What is missing here that a resident might want?

Answer key: contract scavenger hunt

1. 30 days, but the Agency can extend it with no stated limit, so the clause alone does not set a firm maximum.
2. The Agency decides, “as Agency determines appropriate.” Nothing requires a public agreement.
3. All fees due for the then-current term, which could be most of the 10-year term.
4. The contract renews automatically for another 5 years.
5. Use anonymized data to improve its services. Students should notice that “anonymized” is not defined.
6. The Agency has to ask. Missing: regular reports without a request, a deadline for delivering the logs, and any review of what the logs show.

Answer key: exit ticket (sample answers)

1. A statement is what someone says they will do. A contract term is written into the agreement, so it can be enforced. 2. Answers vary; look for a specific city or court, the decision, and a real gap in the story. 3. Answers vary; look for a specific, answerable question.

Answer key: worksheet claim vs. evidence (look for)

A: the number of cases, how many were solved, and whether plate data was the reason. B: counts and outcomes over a period, published rather than described. C: a contract clause or written policy stating 14 days.

Mock council meeting

About 40 minutes. Students play the parts below. Nobody plays a real person: use the role names, not real names.

Agenda

1. Call to order (Mayor, 1 minute)
2. Chief's report (2 minutes). The Chief describes the plan and the promises: no livestreaming, a 14-day trial, a monthly audit.
3. Questions to the Chief and the vendor representative (4 minutes)
4. Public comment (up to 2 minutes each, 3 to 5 residents)
5. Council discussion (6 minutes)
6. Vote (1 minute). Each alder gives a one-sentence reason.

Role cards

Mayor. Runs the meeting fairly. Makes sure everyone gets their time. Does not argue a side.

Alder who supports the plan. Points to what police say the cameras help with. Asks what will be written down.

Alder who is skeptical. Worries about long records and sharing. Asks what happens if the city wants out.

Alder who is undecided. Wants evidence. Asks for numbers and for the contract.

Police Chief. Describes the plan and the promises. Remember: promises are statements, not contract terms.

Vendor representative. Explains what the product does. Cannot make promises the contract does not contain.

Resident (parent). Asks about children's privacy and who can see the data.

Resident (student). Asks how students can find out what is happening and speak up.

Resident (small business owner). Asks about cost and whether it makes the community safer.

After the vote, each student writes one paragraph: what did you decide, and what one fact most influenced you?

Interview a neighbor

Ask permission first. Ask for a first name only, and whether you may share what they say.

Questions

1. Before today, did you know Sun Prairie police use plate reader cameras?
2. If the city signs a contract, what is one thing you would want written down?
3. What is one question you would ask the Chief?

Record

First name: _____ OK to share my answers: yes / no

Answer 1:

_____

__

_____

__

Answer 2:

_____

__

_____

__

Answer 3:

_____

__

_____

__

Best quote (with OK):

Public comment workshop

A good comment is short, specific and respectful. Two minutes is about 250 words spoken at a normal pace. Check each meeting’s agenda for how public comment works.

Steps

1. Say who you are and why you care, in one sentence.
2. Say what you are not arguing. For example: “I am not here to say plate readers are good or bad.”
3. Name one fact, with its source.
4. Make two or three specific requests. Make them things the council can actually do.
5. Thank them. Stop.

Draft

Time it: read it out loud once. Is it under two minutes? Cut one sentence.

Fact-check challenge

Pick one claim on sunprairiealpr.netlify.app and trace it to its source.

Steps

1. Copy the claim exactly.
2. Find the source the site links. Open it.
3. Does the source say the same thing? Same numbers, same date?
4. Is the source the person who made the claim, or someone describing it?
5. If something is off, tell Zack through the Contact tab. It will be fixed and listed in the corrections log, with your credit if you want it.

Claim:

_____

_____

_____

Source:

_____

_____

Does it match? What did you find?

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

_____

Mock public records request

For practice. Under Wisconsin’s public records law you can ask orally or in writing. You generally do not have to say who you are or why. You do need to describe the records or the time period reasonably, and you can only request records that already exist. If you ask in writing and are denied, the denial must be in writing with reasons. (Source: Wisconsin Department of Justice public records guide.) Pick a topic your teacher approves, such as a school policy, and fill in the blanks.

Draft

To: [Records custodian]

Subject: Public records request

Under Wisconsin’s public records law, I request copies of the following records: (1) _____ for the period _____ to _____. (2) _____. Please send them electronically if possible. If you deny any part of this request, please explain the reasons in writing. If any part is redacted, please release the rest. Thank you. [Name, contact]

Check your draft

- Did I describe a subject and a time period?
- Did I ask for records that actually exist, not for answers to questions?
- Did I ask for the format I want?
- Did I say I want any denial in writing?

Letter to the editor template

About 150 words. Sign it with your real name. Check the paper’s rules for length and how to submit.

Structure

1. Opening: what you are writing about, in one sentence.
2. One fact, with where it comes from.
3. One concern or hope, in your own voice.
4. One specific request of the city.
5. Close with your name and neighborhood.

Draft

Three-minute informative speech outline

An informative speech explains. It does not argue. That makes it a good fit for Forensics practice, a class presentation or a club.

Outline

1. Hook (20 seconds): “Imagine a camera that writes down every license plate that drives past, with the time and place.”
2. Point 1 (50 seconds): What a plate reader records, and what it does not (faces). What retention means.
3. Point 2 (50 seconds): What is changing: the move from Flock to Axon, the three-month trial, no vote date posted, final budget approval on Nov. 17.
4. Point 3 (50 seconds): What is said and what is written. Promises about no livestreaming and audits are statements, not contract terms. Other cities have ended, banned or switched.
5. Call to action (20 seconds): Read the sources, ask your alder what will be written down, and speak up before the vote.
6. Closing line: “The question is not just whether we use the technology. It is who writes the rules.”